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Scott Robinson

In the tradition of the multi-instrumentalists of the small jazz bands of the 1920s, Scott Robinson excels on multiple brass and reed horns. He has found a special niche in the jazz world today on the C melody, bass and baritone saxophones, as well as maintaining a reputation as a fine soloist and ensemble player on the more familiar brass and reed instruments. He shares his home with over two hundred horns and is always searching for rare additions for the collection. Scott has recorded with many jazz greats, including Frank Wess, Louie Bellson and Toshiko Akiyoshi. Recently he has recorded as a leader for Arbors Records where he chose to feature the rare and imposing contrabass saxophone on his release "Thinking Big." A constant traveler, he has appeared at festivals in Europe, Japan and the Caribbean as well as jazz events at the Smithsonian and Carnegie Hall.

Scott was interviewed at the Allegheny Jazz Party in Chautauqua, New York on September 13, 1997 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: That was a good set.

SR: It got better. I couldn't play anything on the first tune, it was embarrassing. But it happens sometimes. Music can be embarrassing. It's like dropping your drawers every time you get up you know.

MR: It's true. Exposed.

SR: You wouldn't believe the dreams that musicians have. Are you a musician?

MR: Yes.

SR: Okay well then you probably have had them all. I had one recently where I was late on stage to play with a big orchestra, a big symphony orchestra. And I was late and I realized oh, man, I'm supposed to be on stage. And I got my horn and I got to the side of the stage and then I realized I don't have my tie on — I'm in a tuxedo with no tie. So I find my tie and I put the thing on and I'm like oh, man, and I go out on the stage and the orchestra is playing already, right? And the conductor is going like this. And I just walk out on the stage and I'm like where am I supposed to sit? And I'm stepping through the violins and the violas, like looking around for my stand, and where am I supposed to sit — like in front of the whole audience you know, it's really, really embarrassing. I couldn't find any saxophones anywhere. Where am I? And then finally I looked back in the other wing, and I saw a saxophone player. So I got all the way over to him, and I went crashing through the whole orchestra, to the other side of the stage, and I went up and I said "where are the saxophones sitting?" And he said, "We're not on until the Ellington."

MR: Was the camera rolling on that? Yeah, well, we may splice that in at the end. Good story. I hope it's not a harbinger of things to come.

MR: We're filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive today in Chautauqua, New York, and I'm pleased to have Scott Robinson, saxophonist, with us. Welcome.

SR: Thank you.

MR: You just got off a pretty hot set downstairs with some good competition.

SR: Very good competition. It's a little daunting sometimes when you get some guys up there playing a whole lot of tenor. I go through long periods of not playing any tenor because I get calls to play a lot of baritone and bass clarinet and whatever. So now suddenly I get to play the tenor which I love. But on the other hand it takes me a little while to get over feeling like an idiot. By the end of the set I didn't feel like an idiot, but at the beginning of the set I really did feel like an idiot. But that's all part of the fun.

MR: I hear some Lester Young in what you play. Am I off the mark with that?

SR: No certainly not. Lester is I think my favorite clarinet player and a great composer and great tenor player. My first '78 I ever bought was Lester Young, "Sometimes I'm Happy" and "Afternoon of a Basie-ite" on Keynote with Johnny Guarnieri and Slam Stewart. And I was just telling Phil Atterbury from the *Mississippi Rag* that I met Slam Stewart in a club in Annapolis, Maryland and I went up and I said, "You know I've have this great record that you're on and it meant so much to me through the years." And he says, "Oh, yeah, "Sometimes I'm Happy — do you remember my solo on that?" And he started singing it. And I knew it very well because I'd listened to the record a hundred times. So we were standing in the club singing this solo together. It was a great moment. Everybody is like what are those two doing? But I was amazed that he would just — that was, what was that, 1943 or some time. I don't remember the year. But I was amazed that he could just remember his solo off of that record and just say "oh yeah, I remember that" and start singing it. It's amazing. I still can't get over that.

MR: You had a pretty good experience in high school and so forth with jazz?

SR: Well I was a jazz freak and I converted a few of my closest friends to being jazz freaks, and some of them had driver's licenses before I did, so I was able to cajole them into driving into Washington D.C. — I grew up in Virginia. And we'd go to Blues Alley. And at Blues Alley I heard Earl Hines and Clark Terry and Lockjaw Davis and Dizzy Gillespie, Bobby Hackett, Zoot Sims — a lot of great, great musicians. And I would sit right in front with a glass of water, and just take a lesson. It was great. I did that as often as I could. But it was hard because I didn't drive. And later I got a driver's license and I was able to go in myself. But those years in high school were a little tough in a way because it was frustrating. I tried to have a band, I put a little group together, and I was rehearsing it, and it's hard — we couldn't get any work, we couldn't get guys to rehearse, I could never get the bass player to bring his bow because I was always writing thing where I wanted arco bass, and the bass player never wanted to bring the bow. It was a

little bit of a struggle. So when I finally got to college, Berklee College of Music in Boston, suddenly I was surrounded with people that wanted to do what I was trying to do.

MR: They had the same passion as you perhaps.

SR: Yeah, it's like let's rehearse, let's play jam sessions with the right tunes, we used to rehearse all the time, let's get together this afternoon, let's see how slow we can play, let's see how fast we can play, let's do duets, let's do just tenor and drums. You know, trying every possible thing. It was really great, a great time.

MR: And you went on to be a faculty member there.

SR: For about a year and a half, a part timer.

MR: Teaching saxophone.

SR: Um hum, teaching ensembles and instrument repair, and the history of tenor saxophone styles.

MR: Wow. Were the students, did you try to get the students to play styles like that or was it mostly a listening thing.

SR: No it was a listening, it was a lecture class. It was listening and history, and identifying records, identifying players, stuff like that. It was hard because these people for the most part never heard of Chu Berry or — maybe they knew Lester Young and they probably knew the name Ben Webster but had never heard him play. Really. Tenor players even. So it was kind of a struggle. I had to say listen for this type of sound and this way of turning a phrase around, and then I would quiz them by playing records, to try to get them to identify the players. It was difficult. There were very few that really wanted to go home and listen on their own and find out what was really going on with the instrument. You know most young music students, they just want to play as much stuff on the horn as they can, you know, I don't have time to sit for hours and listen to Lester Young and Chu Berry, I've got to get the horn out and play all these scales and chords as fast as I can. That's the disease. that's the music college disease. So I was happy to play my tiny role in attempting to alleviate that particular affliction.

MR: I haven't quite heard it put like that but I know what you're saying, and some people have echoed that as far as the jazz education and how it trains players — the fact that there's not all the opportunities to play that there used to be I guess is a little hard to overcome, don't you think?

SR: Opportunities to play, do you mean in the music school situation or out of that?

MR: Out of it.

SR: Yeah. Well what I find is there's incredible opportunities to play in an unbelievably wide variety of contexts. You know I do everything from the most classic jazz kind of thing — Marty Grosz and Peter Ecklund for example — to Anthony Braxton large orchestra, I played with the opera, I played with pop people, Elton John and people like that. In New

York particularly, it's amazing how many different situations one finds himself in — film scores and whatnot. But what is lacking is the chance to actually have a group and play regularly, night after night with a group and develop a sound, develop a conception and a direction for your music. That's what's hard to do. It's like you get plugged in here and plugged in there, and plugged in to all these different situations. But it's really hard unless you either struggle quite a bit or unless you're sort of one of the new young sensations or something like that then you're able to travel with your group and play all the festivals and all of that. But that's the element I think is missing. In the old days groups played together night after night after night after night. And that's how the music grows.

MR: You've become quite a woodwind specialist and do things that not that many other people do, like the bass saxophone and so forth. How did you get into that low end of the spectrum?

SR: Well the bass sax is a passion of mine. I have to say it's probably my favorite of the saxophones, although I can actually do more on the tenor for now.

MR: When you say "do more" do you mean play more?

SR: I can be more flexible and play in more situations. I have better range and better control. But I've taken the bass sax to where I can feel very comfortable on it in almost any situation. And I hope to take it to the level where it will be just another tenor for me, but of course an octave lower. In answer to your question about getting into the bass sax, I started on alto. I started on my grandfather's alto, which I still play today, it's a Conn that he bought in 1927 and he played with a little dance band when he was in school, along with my grandmother, she played the violin. And I dearly wish I had a picture of them in that group but none exist. Then I switched to baritone, because baritone was needed in the high school — or not in high school, in the junior high band. I went from alto right to baritone. It wasn't until high school that I started playing tenor. I thought the baritone was a huge, monster instrument, and then somebody told me, "You know there's one even bigger and that's bass saxophone." I said, "Come on." "No there is, and Herndan High School has one." And I didn't believe it but I finally got my first chance to go into Herndan High School and I saw this thing in the band room and it was just amazing to me. So I started carrying it home and borrowing it and playing on it. The band director was very nice, he let me take it home, and I walked back and forth to school and I was a little gangly little kid carrying this incredibly heavy thing in a wooden case, carrying it through these fields, which are now all built up unfortunately. But I remember the handle was on the sloping part of the case and it was a hard, kind of a sharp edged handle, and it was on the slope, so all the weight was pulled down right into this part of my hand like this, and it was agony. But man, when I got that thing home, I sure had a ball with it.

MR: You were paying some dues just getting it home.

SR: Oh, boy, I said, this is really something. And I dreamed of someday having one. And I finally did get one. It's a long story but there was one at another high school that was completely banged up and unplayable and I had seen it there once. And so after I got to college I got thinking about it and I said I want that horn. I started calling down there and asking about it. And they said, "Oh it belongs to the school and we can't part with it" and all that. But just to shorten the story, after twelve years, the guy retired and a new band director came in and he said we can't use this thing, we're going to put it on an obsolete list and then we can get rid of it. So I went down and I made a special trip down there to see it and he got it out and it was all old and a couple of parts were missing and he says, "Oh gee, I didn't realize it was that bad," he says, "Well if you donate fifty bucks to the band department, we'll give you the horn." So I got this horn that I restored, and I made the keys for it and everything.

MR: No kidding. You made it yourself?

SR: Yeah. I knew I was going to get one someday. I had already written a piece for it called "Rapture of the Deep." And sometimes that seems to be a good way to get an instrument I need, if I write music for it, then it sets up a kind of gravitational field and eventually I think it will come to me.

MR: Wow. And you've been using that on some of the classic jazz, as we see in that recent *Jazz Times* picture, which is really nice, which we'll probably insert in this video. Tell me about that particular concert and what is the function of the bass saxophone in that classic jazz?

SR: Well that's where the instrument has seen its primary use. Of course Adrian Rollini is the acknowledged master of the bass saxophone. He played in the '20s on all those great records with Bix Beiderbecke and so that represents sort of the standard by which that type of use of the instrument is measured. And so Randy Sandke does a lot of Bix's music and Trumbauer and all of that, and he knows I play the C melody too, so I get to sort of be the Trumbauer-Rollini amalgam in those concerts. And it's a lot of fun. But I like to also use the bass saxophone in other situations where it doesn't normally get used. It's a great instrument for ballads. I think it's the ideal instrument for ballads.

MR: No kidding. Can you see bringing one of those to these kind of festivals some day?

SR: Yeah. I brought one to Decatur, the jazz party there, I brought it. But it is hard to travel with. I could have brought it here if I didn't need the baritone but they said they wanted a baritone. So I couldn't really bring both of them. Otherwise if I had a choice I probably would bring a bass sax. It's great. You know, people are really amazed when you get up with the rhythm section and play a really beautiful "Stardust" or something like that on it

— everybody says wow — because they've never heard that instrument used that way. It's a great melodic instrument. And it's great for bebop stuff too, playing fast.

MR: Oh, I've got to hear this. Do they even make them anymore?

SR: In Europe. Nobody makes them in America, but in Europe you can get one. I don't know how good they are.

MR: And of course you're not stopping there either — you're going down another fifth?

SR: I never stop anywhere. I don't acknowledge boundaries of any type.

MR: You have an album coming out with a contrabass?

SR: Yeah. That instrument I never even dreamed of getting, because there's so few in the world, there's like a dozen in the world. But I did happen to meet somebody in Rome, I told them I was looking for old instruments, and he says, "Oh there's this giant saxophone in an antique shop." And I really didn't believe him, because people say, "Oh yeah, it's like higher than that door." And then you go look at it and it's a baritone. That kind of thing happens all the time. But this guy was for real. His name was Enrico. And he was for real with this. And he sent me pictures of it. And I was out of my mind, you know I couldn't sleep. But there again, the guy didn't want to sell it. But he had it just standing up in his antique furniture shop, and he had canes and umbrellas and stuff down inside it. And that took two and a half years, so that was a blink of an eye compared with the bass sax. And finally the guy parted with it and my friend brought it over in a big box the size of a phone booth. I picked him up at the airport and we brought the thing home, and it's just unbelievable. And the amazing thing is how small the bass sax looks next to this. The bass saxophone just — I busted out laughing. We dragged them both out in the yard and we stood them up and the contrabass and then the bass sax is just down here.

MR: So this is an octave below a baritone sax.

SR: Yeah. But it seems proportionately larger somehow than what you would think. I mean it's at least twice the size of the bass sax. Amazing. Taller than me and I'm six-four nearly.

MR: What did they use it for?

SR: Well I would love to know really. It has one of these on it, which is a little mount for a marching lyre.

MR: I hope they put wheels on it.

SR: And I love that and I show it to people and I say, "You know I wouldn't have bought it without that." But it's set up for marching, so I said okay, I'll get it. So I mean maybe it was used in parades.

MR: Could have been the tuba.

SR: Might have been used in parades.

MR: So what's the context of the record you're going to record? Did you use a rhythm section?

SR: You mean the record that's coming out?

MR: Yeah. With the contrabass.

SR: Yeah that's already been recorded. That's coming out next week I think. It's a rhythm section, it's a couple of extra horns on some of the tracks. Dan Barrett's on it, my brother David plays cornet and trumpet on maybe half of it. And the contrabass is on two cuts and the rest, there's a lot of bass sax, there's some sarrousaphone and tenor, C melody and so on. I didn't play any brass on this record.

MR: But you do play brass too.

SR: Yeah, a little bit.

MR: Well that's interesting. I suppose in some sense it's good to specialize in those kind of things because you have less competition. How many guys around play bass sax? And wasn't there a bass saxophone on a Paul Simon record, "Graceland?" I remember seeing someone playing the bass sax, just on that one tune.

SR: I don't know. I don't know too much about pop music.

MR: And I recognized the name too — there's one other guy that does it occasionally. I can't think of it at the moment.

SR: Well it's possible. My brother is working on a discography of the bass saxophone. He's been doing it for years, and he's dug up a lot of incredibly obscure items. And there's some classical things, shows and movie music and different things that you wouldn't necessarily know about. There's a lot of stuff out there besides the Adrian Rollini and Spencer Clark stuff.

MR: Interesting. You've done some writing too, is that correct?

SR: Yeah. On the new record I chose not to do any composing. I just wanted to arrange. I did arrangements of a lot of Duke things and some different, kind of obscure tunes. But yeah I like to write, I like to compose. Frank Wess asked me to do some writing for him. He's started an octet with two saxophones, just him and myself, and two trumpets and a trombone. It's a really nice little band, and I'm very honored to be asked by such a great writer to write, and by such a great saxophone player to be the other saxophone in his band. I was thrilled with that. So we have two records out on Concord. And he just came up to me the other day and said he wants to do some rehearsals and do some music so he wants me to write some more stuff.

MR: Cool. What about — you've also done some writing for publications?

SR: Oh, not too much. I did an article for *Saxophone Journal* about the bass sax, and I was just asked to write liner notes so that will be a first. I mean I wrote my own liner notes once before but this is for Storyville Records, a record by Klaus Suonsaari, the great

Finnish drummer. I enjoy a little bit of writing. I'm not like my father, he's a real writer. He's retired from *National Geographic*, and he can really write. For me it's kind of a laborious process.

MR: Did your parents think you were a little weird to be hauling this bass saxophone home by the way?

SR: They probably thought I was a little weird. I don't know if that would have been the reason. But no I think they both appreciate music and they both got a kick out of that. And you know my father, it's his father's saxophone that I'm playing, and my brother played my dad's cornet, and now I have my mother's piano that she left to me. So it all ties in there. No we were not subject to any of that — you know — you're not going to play the devil's music — or any of that stuff. You hear a lot of those stories. Fortunately I didn't have to contend with anything like that. It's always been a very supportive atmosphere. Now some of the music I've played through the years has certainly raised some eyebrows and I think there was a period when my parents were a little concerned about whether I was really going to go out in the world and play some of this music. I think those concerns have been put to rest. My dad has seen me out here surviving and he's seen me on "The Letterman Show" and CNN stuff, so I think he knows I'm all right.

MR: So you're legitimate.

SR: Yeah.

MR: Tell me about your visit to the Black Caucus Jazz Forum.

SR: Oh, when was that? That was — it must have been like eight years ago or something. That's — Congressman John Conyers holds that every year. It's the Congressional Black Caucus. They meet and discuss jazz related issues. This is where the resolution to declare jazz a national treasure, this is how that was engendered, through these meetings and these discussions. They called me up and said well we're having a panel about jazz and the family, and we want you to come and speak. And I don't really come from a jazz family, but maybe they knew about my brother. They didn't have him on the list, so I called him up and I told them they should call him up. So both of us were there. And one of the Marsalis brothers was there — I think it was Branford, Branford was there. And we were chums from college anyway.

MR: Oh. At Berklee together?

SR: Yeah. And also Thelonious Monk Jr. was there and I started doing some playing with him, in fact I played the bass sax with his — oh it was a tentet I think they had, playing the music of Monk. So we just went around and talked a little bit about how we got involved in jazz and all of that. And of course in most cases it does come through the family somehow. You know our father had old '78s. How many times have you heard that story? We listened to dad's '78s and got all excited about the music. There you go.

He had Firehouse Five, and Louis Armstrong and various things. So that's what got my brother and I all fired up about Hot music.

MR: Do you have an opinion on the racial state of jazz these days? I think of it when I'm at a function like this, that the audience is all white and —

SR: And the bands are all white.

MR: With the exception of one player at this particular festival. And it seems to be the case. The only difference I've seen was a jazz cruise that I went on once, and I don't know, do you have an indication of why that's happened?

SR: That's a very complicated issue. I think it has something to do with the stratification of this music. You know it's like an oreo cookie that people are always trying to take apart and just get at one layer of it somehow. You know there's so many different factions and different camps, and well there's got to be classic jazz, and well how do we define that, well it's got to be this or that, it's got to be like Chicago school or it's got to be Oliver-Armstrong-Hardin thing or the Austin High gang, or it's got to be the Condon thing. And then you've got the bebop faction and what they call the avante garde and it's all so stratified. And everybody's trying to pick out a certain layer of it and sweep all the others aside. And I think that must have something to do with it. Because at these kind of events the entire spectrum of the music is not really presented of course. It's a quote unquote mainstream traditional/mainstream segment of the music. And I think that maybe the black audiences are not attracted to that. The black audiences are certainly there. I mean I've played at the Jackie Robinson Foundation, Afternoon for Jazz which is held annually, and that was one of the best times I ever had at a festival. I did it this year also, but I did it two years ago. This year it was with Thelonious Monk Jr. and two years ago it was Frank Wess's band with Frank Foster as a guest soloist, and I don't know how many people were there but just a huge sea of people, almost all black people. And they are very, very enthusiastic and very, very happy to hear this music. And they come up and they say, "Thank you — thank you for coming here and playing this music for us. We hunger for this, this is just great." And many of the performers were black. But they treated us so nicely. They had all this great food — collard greens and yams and all of that, and they're like, "Oh can we carry your instruments?" We were fantastically well treated and I remember leaving there and this woman came up and said, "Please come back, please. You come back here and play for us again." And I had just come from an event, more of this genre, and I felt like everybody was kind of like apathetic. I'm not talking about this event.

MR: Yeah, I know what you mean.

SR: I'll leave the event unnamed. But everything was white, all the musicians were white, all the audience was white, the music clung to a relatively narrow band of the spectrum of

jazz possibilities, it was very safe, and I felt like okay, now there's a lesson to be learned here somewhere, you know? Is it possible that we could make these events more inclusive, and present a little wider spectrum of the music and bring more people into it and maybe people from this kind of camp would discover that hey, this stuff's pretty good and people from that kind of camp would say hey, you know. I would like to have things mixed up a little bit. A little of this then a little of that, and I'm not afraid of being shocked or of shocking people. So I don't know, I think it might be possible to present a little wider spectrum and have a more balanced audience.

MR: It's a little scary for the future of some of this music when you look at the audience and I doubt there's many people at this festival that are under 55 you know. And you wonder, are there going to be younger listeners that at least come in to this particular style of music?

SR: Right. Well there again at the Jackie Robinson Festival there were all ages there. There were families and there were little kids and there were young amateur players, and it was a wider segment. So we need to bring those people in. I mean that would be great if we could bring those people in. Of course something like this, I don't know, I'm not the type to be able to put something like this together, but I think it ought to be possible somehow to bring in families and younger people. Because it happens in these other kind of situations.

MR: Well you've certainly played in an awful lot of big band situations. Do you like big band — Illinois Jacquet and those kind of things?

SR: Yeah. I enjoy every kind of playing. I don't have any particular love of big bands as a lot of people do, nor do I despise it. But playing with a great band, I mean you mentioned Illinois Jacquet and at the time I was in the band it was a really great band and a wonderful learning experience. And also Mel Lewis, playing with Mel Lewis' band and touring with him, that was a great experience too. So yeah, I'm always thrilled and delighted to play with a great band playing great music. Thad Jones' music is indescribably amazing, so that will never get old. I'll play that stuff anytime.

MR: Are you your own business agent? Do you have an agent that sends you work or are you pretty much—

SR: No I function as my business agent, booking agent, PR person, shipping clerk, roadie, and everything else. And I'm not good at most of those functions.

MR: A lot of musicians have trouble with the areas that need to be taken care of outside their playing. It's hard.

SR: Well there's few of us that — anybody like that is interested in. So nobody's interested in booking Scott Robinson or producing. You know anything I'm going to do, other than answering the phone and going to play with this orchestra or that band, anything beyond

that either I'm going to do it or it's not going to happen. So most of the time it doesn't happen. But every once in a while — I went through a phase in the '80s of really getting on the phone and booking myself in Europe and stuff like that. And I had some scary experiences and I got a little bit frightened away from that. And now I'm trying to gingerly sort of get back to the stage of trying to not just be a sideman the rest of my life. I think I'm starting to come out of my shell a little bit. Maybe the giant saxophone is going to help me with that.

MR: Sounds like an album title, doesn't it?

SR: Yeah.

MR: Scott and his Giant Sax — it sounds like a kid's book Scott and his Giant Saxophone.

SR: Well I used the title "Thinking Big" for the record, but the other title I was thinking of was "The Big Picture." Which do you prefer?

MR: I like "Thinking Big" actually. "The Big Picture" looks too much like some corporate thing — you know, looking down the road, what's our product going to be in twenty years.

SR: Oh I wouldn't think of it like that. I would think of it like, you know, the universe. That's how I would think of it. And of course the saxophone.

MR: Tell me about this particular horn.

SR: This is a Conn, made in 1924. I call it the flop ears because it's got the bell keys on opposite sides, like Dumbo the Elephant. Got the flop ears in there, right? It's a good old horn. It's raggedy, it's old, it's worn out, it leaks.

MR: It's got soul though.

SR: It's got some soul to it. I got it in an antique store for $77.50. It was in Maryland. I was a kid in school and I saw the horn there and I thought God, that's the same as my grandfather's alto, like a matching horn. Seventy-seven dollars? Gee. I went home and then I started agonizing about it. So I called up the store finally and said, "Do you still have that tenor saxophone?" They said, "Oh that was stolen." I said, "Really? It was stolen?" And they said, "Yeah, we don't have it. But they caught the guy who was stealing stuff." And I said, "Really?" And they said, "Yeah, we might get it back." So this started a long process. For months this went on and I kept calling them, and now I'm out of my mind — I should have bought that tenor, I should have bought that tenor. Finally they said, "Okay, we got the horn back, but we're supposed to hold it as evidence. We're not supposed to sell it until this whole case has been resolved." And the thing dragged on and on. And finally I called them once again and they said, "All right, you know what? Come up here and get the horn." So I drove up and bought the horn. Boy was I happy.

MR: Boy. Every instrument you have seems to have a story behind it.

SR: Yeah. Because I root around in antique shops and flea markets and I'm always, my hands are all dusty and dirty, going through piles of stuff, and you come across a lot of great things that way, and it's a lot of fun.

MR: How many instruments do you own?

SR: Oh a couple of hundred probably.

MR: No kidding?

SR: Yeah, a lot, a lot. I have a whole big, it's a sickness. Visit me if you're in West New York/New Jersey, come over and visit me and you won't believe what you see. I can't believe it and I live there.

MR: All right. Well I know that you've got to report downstairs and see what their schedule's like.

SR: Yeah. I'm guessing we're still pretty far behind.

MR: What do you think about advice to a seventeen year old aspiring jazz musician these days.

SR: Listen. That's my advice. Listen. And everything else grows out of that. You know if you listen to great music, you'll get excited about it, you'll get ideas, you'll start wanting to transcribe, you'll start wanting to learn those tunes, you'll start wanting to figure out, how do they get that kind of sound out of the horn, that sound is like – you know, and you start fooling around. And you start thinking, well maybe I could write something, or maybe I could start a group and so you start writing and composing. Everything comes out of listening. That's how it starts. You hear music, I mean, and you go wow — is it possible that maybe I could actually do that someday? Is that possible? And you start trying to find out. I'm still trying to find out.

MR: Well I think you're searching pretty well. And I wish you the best of luck with your new recordings with Frank Wess which I'm sure is a real gas, and everything else that you manage to do. Thanks for sharing your time, on behalf of Hamilton College.

SR: Thanks, Monk. All right. Thank you.